The Whole Shebang

By Rich Orloff

Throughout the play, switch out gender references to match the gender of the student actor – The script is written to allow the student to be of either gender.

(The STUDENT enters. He/She carries a globe, a briefcase and some papers, etc. He/she appears very anxious and pressured.)

DEAN: Please relax. This is just an informal review.

STUDENT: You told me my grade depends on this.

DEAN: *(Comforting)* Try not to think about it. Why don't we begin with a brief summary of your project?

STUDENT: All right. For my master's thesis, I elected to devise a self-sustaining and self-evolving, matter based ecosystem in a universe of three dimensions. And so I created the heavens and the earth.

DEAN: Now that you've devised this planetary ecosystem, how do you feel about it?

STUDENT: Well, to be honest . . . I think it's good.

PROF B: Could you be a little more specific?

STUDENT: Certainly. I think the Earth has succeeded in every way I hoped it would. The weather cycle, given its complexity, is quite efficient. All in all, the Earth is fundamentally capable of sustaining itself.

DEAN: I'm most impressed with your creation of water.

PROF A: I must admit, so am I. It may be one of the most efficient liquids any student has designed.

PROF B: I like how when the temperature drops below freezing, you've designed it so that water falls as snowflakes instead of ice cubes.

STUDENT: Thanks. That took a lot of work.

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DEAN: *(Reviewing paper:)* Here's a most impressive statistic: Over 453 zillion snowflakes so far, and only 12 have been alike.

STUDENT: Thanks.

PROF A: By the way, why did you have an ice age?

STUDENT: I . . . I . . . well to be honest, I screwed [messed] up.

DEAN: Well that happens.

INTRODUCTION

What if God was one of us? Just a cute little nerd like . . . you. Or a totally awesome person like . . . YOU. Yeah? In Rich Orloff's The Whole Shebang we take a playful look at the creation and evaluation of earth, humans, and everything in between.

PROF A: Can we begin discussing the human being?

STUDENT: I consider the human being to be the crowning achievement of my universe.

PROF A: I have one question regarding the human being. . . Why did you make them so stupid?

STUDENT: I think they're smart. They've created great civilizations. They've developed magnificent tools and brilliant works of art. Their awareness of the universe is increasing exponentially.

PROF A: Stop exaggerating. It took them centuries just to come up with the concept of a sandwich.

STUDENT: May I remind you the human being is the sole creature capable of transforming milk into all those other products. Without the human being the Earth would have been a mass of raw material with unrealized potential.

PROF A: Are you saying it's a better planet because of cheese doodles?

STUDENT: There's more to the picture than that.

DEAN: Why did you give these creatures domain over the planet?

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STUDENT: Well, you see . . . *(The Student sighs and checks his watch.)* My roommate was supposed to transport a couple of human beings here so I could…It's very hard to understand them unless you meet them up close. They really are wondrous creatures. *(From the hallway we hear voices.)*

HARVEY: *(Offstage:)* What do you mean, "go in there"?! Maybe I don't want to go in there!

EDNA: *(To man)* Don't cause a scene.

HARVEY: This jerk's causing the scene! Look buddy. I don't know who you are, but I'll go in there when I'm good and ready.

(A Man (HARVEY) comes flying into the room as if he was thrown in by someone else. A Woman (EDNA) follows quickly. Both are dressed for bed. They look around, quite bewildered about what's going on.)

HARVEY: What the –

STUDENT: Oh, good. Just in time. I'm so glad you're finally here. *(The Student pulls up a couple of chairs.)* Make yourselves at home.

EDNA: *(Frightened)* Where are we?

STUDENT: Relax. This won't take long…Please. *(The Humans look at each other and hesitantly sit down.) (To the Professors)* I'd like to introduce two typical human beings:

HARVEY: Uh, can I ask a question? . . . Who the hell are you, and why are we here?

STUDENT: Well, since you asked, my roommate teleported through a warp in dimensional barriers, where he realigned your molecules into a pure energetic code. *(To the Humans)* Don't worry. This is just what, in our dimension, is the equivalent of one of your universities. These are professors in my department and I'm a student. You're here as part of my project.

HARVEY: Oh yeah? And what's your project?

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STUDENT: I created the heavens and the earth. *(It takes a moment for this to fully sink in on the Humans.)*

HARVEY: Wait a second. Are you telling us that you're –

STUDENT: I am who I am.

EDNA: Sounds like him.

HARVEY: You mean to tell us that, like the entire universe is just like . . . a science fair project?

STUDENT: More or less.

HARVEY: I work my fingers to the bone and all I am is part of some nerd's science project?!

EDNA: Harvey please *(Whispering;)* You'll go to hell.

HARVEY: Eh, I don't care. With my luck, I could give the Pope CPR and I'd still go to hell.

DEAN: Now then, Harvey and Edna, why don't you tell us a little about yourselves?

EDNA: Not much to say. We're just people. Ordinary people.

PROF A: Do the two of you have children?

EDNA: Oh yes. Michael, who's sixteen and Wendy who's just about thirteen.

PROF A: What do they excel at? *(Harvey and Edna think about this. Nothing comes to mind.)*

EDNA: Michael was just made group leader at his drug rehabilitation center.

PROF B: Does Wendy take drugs?

EDNA: Oh, no. Never.

HARVEY: She spends all day in the bathroom, dyeing her hair unnatural colors.

EDNA: *(Trying to put things in a good light:)* Some of which are very creative.

HARVEY: Yeah, like one day her head's going to end up in an art gallery.

EDNA: She's going through a rough time. She still hasn't gotten over the shock of menstruation.

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HARVEY: *(To the Student)* Not to question your ways or nothing, but couldn't you think of anything better than *puberty*?

STUDENT: No, not really. I tried.

EDNA: Harvey, please.

HARVEY: Well, he's supposed to be all- knowing and all-powerful and he can't even make their teeth grow in straight. *(To the Student:)* Do you know how much that cost me?

EDNA: Harvey, please. We're supposed to be representing the entire human race.

PROF A: I think you're doing a *splendid* job.

PROF B: Do you believe that intimacy is important in a relationship?

EDNA: I think intimacy is the keystone of a healthy relationship. I read it in last month's Cosmo.

PROF A: Harvey and Edna, what would you say has been the best moment of your lives?

EDNA: Oh that's easy. It was the day Harvey proposed to me. It was the first day of spring, and we were having a picnic in the park. I had made chicken salad sandwiches and potato salad and carrot-raisin salad and macaroni salad – Anyway, so we were having this picnic, and when we finished eating, I wiped Harvey's mouth with my napkin, and he wiped my mouth with his---

HARVEY: It's this thing we do.

EDNA: And, and I remember, I remember Harvey looking right in my eyes and saying . . . "Let's make it legal." And I thought, this man knows what I want.

PROF B: If I may, I have one final question. Do you think the world is getting better or worse?

HARVEY: Oh, worse.

EDNA: Much worse. Everyone knows that.

PROF A: Then why do you keep living?

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HARVEY: Whaddaya mean?

PROF A: Your lives vary in quality from boring to dismal. Your future holds no promise. Why do you keep living? *(Harvey and Edna think for a moment, look at each other.)*

EDNA: I just dropped ten pounds. I'm not going to die now.

PROF A: And this is why you keep on living?

EDNA: Well, well, we also have to stick around for the kids. After all, if it weren't for us, who'd be their role models? *(The Professors exchange looks with each other.)*

HARVEY: *(To Edna:)* I think you just blew it.

PROF A: I still don't understand. With your attitudes, why do you two keep living?

HARVEY: Hey, if you're suggesting I drop dead, *forget it*. It'd make too many people happy.

EDNA: There are things in life to look forward to, you know. Special things, things that make life worth living.

PROF A: Name three.

EDNA: Well . . . every Thursday the paper has double discount coupons…And on weekends, I get to sleep in late . . . Oh, and about every six months somebody'll say "thank you" like they really mean it.

PROF A: Don't you think those are rather trivial things?

HARVEY: I don't think you guys realize how hard it is being a human being.

STUDENT: You're missing the point! I didn't create the human being so that each one would work perfectly. I created the human being so that humanity as a whole would work perfectly.

DEAN: Thank you. We've decided your grade. There is much that is commendable about your project, both in Earth's evolutionary ability and its astonishing variety of beauty. The human being is wondrous and fascinating.

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Nevertheless – the human being's design is tragically flawed. I'm afraid we're going to have to give you a C plus.

STUDENT: C Plus?!!!

DEAN: I'm sorry. The grade is final.

PROF A: *(To the Student:)* You want my advice? Next time, don't design them in your own image. It's very narcissistic. *(Exits)*

DEAN: *(To the Student:)* Now don't be too hard on yourself. You did your best.

STUDENT: That makes it even more depressing.

DEAN: It's only a universe. It'll pass. *(Exits.) (The Student starts to clean up.)*

EDNA: Sorry if we blew your grade.

STUDENT: It's my fault. I never should have goofed off on the seventh day.

EDNA: Well, if it means anything, we are glad you created us.

HARVEY: I mean, I think we're completely messed up; but I'm glad we're here.

STUDENT: Thanks. I better have you teleported back to Earth.

HARVEY: Oh, yea, well, sure.

EDNA: By the way, if there is such a thing as reincarnation –

HARVEY: Could you bring me back as an Eagle? Just once I'd like to fly real high on my own power, real high, so I could look down and get a clear view of the whole shebang.

STUDENT: That's a very nice desire Harvey.

HARVEY: Yeah well, I got my moments.

STUDENT: Shall we go? . . . After you.

(Harvey and Edna exit. The Student is about to go, but then he turns around and picks up the globe.<possibly giving it one last spin.>)

STUDENT: *(Shrugs to himself:)* I think it's good. *(The Student sighs, puts the globe under his arm, and exits. The lights fade.)*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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